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Shailesh Sawlani
VP, Country GM
Audible India

from us in the year 2000 which was years before the word podcast came to be. So this is one of those ‘dream come true’ moments for me, where we’re just doing a purely creative launch and having no barriers to listening for anybody, whether they have money or they don’t.

SHAILESH SAWLANI

Coming to your point on ‘why India and why do this now’. I think this is quite a unique situation where you have almost this confluence of factors. First, we have a culture of storytelling that’s manifested in different ways and forms, both across generations as well as in different states right from oral storytelling culture to puppet shows, etc. In the modern scheme of things it even applies to just a really good story sticking out and performing well in a Bollywood setup. There’s that recognition of really good stories. Second, the massive proliferation of digital media, devices and data. The third reason is the creative community that’s thriving and vibrant in India.

So when we actually start to unpack and have these conversations with all the different talent that’s associated with Suno including all the directors, writers and actors, it was clear that the way they’re thinking about this is so unique and so experimental and so fun that it creates a unique audio experience, a unique audible experience. Combine all of these things and it

becomes a really interesting place for us to try something like this. In terms of the awareness of the medium itself, it’s just so low right now that if we can put this out in front of as many people as we can do it for free then that’s the best way for people to experience it.

d With streaming services, what’s been observed in India is that if you have a paid premium service like Netflix or Audible then the adoption is very slow but when you have something free such as Hotstar, the adoption is rapid. Is that what you’re aiming with Audible Suno? You already have a premium service with a massive library that is Audible and then on the side you have a dedicated podcast app, Suno, which could act like a funnel for listeners to move into Audible.

SHAILESH SAWLANI

When it comes to Audible Suno, the objective was plain and simple. In fact, we didn’t even wait to see how the premium service is performing or ponder about what needs to be the direction that we need to take with the premium service. When we were here last year, immediately on that trip itself, we started talking about Audible Suno. So it’s taken a year for us to actually develop this super rich content slate with hundreds of hours of content. I think with Audible Suno, it was just about figuring out how

we can get people to experience what audio entertainment is, and what the Audible experience is. If your question is about the monetisation or the business model then we can figure that out later. It’s a question of spurring the ecosystem of creators and getting the audience prepared for experiences. In fact, the premium service is continuing as is and we are even bolstering it with Hindi and Urdu audiobooks. So we’re quite encouraged by it and we’re investing further into the premium service. Whether Audible Suno has some sort of a macro effect on premium? Maybe, maybe not. I think it will evolve over time as we learn more and more.

d With India, it’s often a slightly risky environment when you’re trying to push out content, especially with the talk show format where you can have a highly opinionated persona who might offend a segment of the society. So do you have stricter guidelines for creators in India?

SHAILESH SAWLANI

We’re another place for creators to tell their stories. As a company, we believe in equality and inclusion, and that somehow manifests in some of the content that we’re doing and so on. But I think largely it’s another avenue for creators to tell their stories. And the creators are sensible in regards to how they approach such topics.

DON KATZ

You have to look at our People Principles, particularly *Activate Caring* and the way we want to give voice to different kinds of views. Inciting people to hurt other people, deeply exploitative or hate-filled things would be easily taken down from the platform. We come from a relatively U.S. First Amendment View. If it’s in a public library and even if it’s historically negative, then we don’t censor it. If we have to modulate that because of a given country’s laws or sensitivity then we play by the rules. I think our repertoire is pretty broad in terms of allowing diversity of people with different voices, identities and visions. Notwithstanding sensitivities and sensibilities, we just believe that great stories need to be told. **d**